IB Economics - Topic 4.7: Teacher and AI Grading Guide

Sustainable Development | Questions 1-15

Scope and assessment status

Each original paired question has (a) 10 marks and (b) 15 marks. 12 questions assess SL/HL content; 3 questions are explicitly labelled HL. Difficulty: 3 Easy, 8 Medium, 4 Hard pairs, distributed through the bank. Level and difficulty are independent.

Sustainable development and the Sustainable Development Goals. The poverty-sustainability relationship is HL only.

The uploaded Economics for the IB Diploma textbook (second edition, 2012) was used for conceptual verification. The current guide controls this topic's numbered scope and HL boundaries.

These are original adapted Paper 1-style practice questions, not official IB examination or marking material. The question bank revisits syllabus mechanisms through distinct explanatory and evaluative tasks; the pairs are alternatives for practice, not separate official learning outcomes.

Topic 4.7 specifies sustainable development, the SDGs and one HL poverty-sustainability relationship. Fifteen distinct pairs address those angles; fifty would repeat them or import Topics 4.8–4.10.

Coverage blueprint

Sustainability: Questions 1-7

SDGs: Questions 8-12

HL poverty: Questions 13-15

Marking principles

Use best-fit assessment for each part, not a fixed marks-per-keyword checklist. Credit accurate alternatives addressing the task. Do not require every example or qualification below.

Part (a): 10 marks

Practice bands: 0; 1-2 limited; 3-4 mainly descriptive; 5-6 partial explanation; 7-8 clear and accurate causal analysis; 9-10 fully developed explanation with any required diagram or calculation. These abbreviated bands are not official IB descriptors.

Part (b): 15 marks

Practice bands: 0; 1-3 very limited; 4-6 superficial; 7-9 developed but weakly balanced; 10-12 balanced analysis and evaluation; 13-15 sustained, applied evaluation and supported judgment. A named case alone is not developed application.

Diagram and AI grading

For each diagram explicitly requested, credit an economically correct alternative with proper axes, equilibrium or reference lines, directions of change, and interpretation. Numerical responses require method, units and an explanation; do not award a final number with a contradictory mechanism.

Record separate marks for (a) and (b), band evidence, diagram or numerical features if relevant, economic misconceptions, quality of real-world application, and one actionable improvement per part. If a student drawing is unclear, flag the uncertainty rather than assuming correctness.

Question 1

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: Sustainability

(a) [10] Explain what sustainable development means in terms of present and future needs.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether current economic growth is compatible with sustainable development.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: Present well-being must be pursued without compromising future generations' ability to meet needs; resource use and technology matter.

Required reasoning. Present well-being must be pursued without compromising future generations' ability to meet needs; resource use and technology matter.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes sustainability from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Present well-being must be pursued without compromising future generations' ability to meet needs; resource use and technology matter.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why sustainability may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 2

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: Sustainability

(a) [10] Explain why depletion of non-renewable resources can threaten future well-being.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether saving resource revenues can offset depletion.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: Present well-being must be pursued without compromising future generations' ability to meet needs; resource use and technology matter.

Required reasoning. Extraction uses finite natural capital; reinvestment and substitutes may preserve future capacity.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes sustainability from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Extraction uses finite natural capital; reinvestment and substitutes may preserve future capacity.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why sustainability may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 3

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: Sustainability

(a) [10] Explain why environmental damage can accompany rising GDP.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether higher output necessarily reduces sustainability.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: Present well-being must be pursued without compromising future generations' ability to meet needs; resource use and technology matter.

Required reasoning. GDP counts production while omitting many environmental costs; cleaner methods can reduce damage per unit.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes sustainability from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. GDP counts production while omitting many environmental costs; cleaner methods can reduce damage per unit.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why sustainability may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 4

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: Sustainability

(a) [10] Explain how pollution can impose costs on people who do not produce or consume the polluting good.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether voluntary changes by firms can protect future welfare.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: Present well-being must be pursued without compromising future generations' ability to meet needs; resource use and technology matter.

Required reasoning. Unpriced external costs encourage excessive damage, while norms and policy may alter behaviour.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes sustainability from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Unpriced external costs encourage excessive damage, while norms and policy may alter behaviour.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why sustainability may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 5

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: Sustainability

(a) [10] Explain why protecting renewable resources requires attention to the rate of regeneration.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether a renewable resource can still be exhausted.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: Present well-being must be pursued without compromising future generations' ability to meet needs; resource use and technology matter.

Required reasoning. Use faster than replenishment reduces the stock, as with fish or forests.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes sustainability from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Use faster than replenishment reduces the stock, as with fish or forests.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why sustainability may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 6

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: Sustainability

(a) [10] Explain how improving energy efficiency can support sustainable development.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether efficiency gains always reduce total resource use.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: Present well-being must be pursued without compromising future generations' ability to meet needs; resource use and technology matter.

Required reasoning. Less energy per unit output can reduce pressure, but rebound and total output can offset savings.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes sustainability from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Less energy per unit output can reduce pressure, but rebound and total output can offset savings.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why sustainability may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 7

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: Sustainability

(a) [10] Explain why access to clean water is relevant to sustainable development.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether infrastructure alone guarantees long-term water security.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: Present well-being must be pursued without compromising future generations' ability to meet needs; resource use and technology matter.

Required reasoning. Safe supply supports health and productivity, requiring maintenance and resource management.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes sustainability from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Safe supply supports health and productivity, requiring maintenance and resource management.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why sustainability may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 8

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: SDGs

(a) [10] Explain how the Sustainable Development Goals link economic and social objectives.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether progress on income goals alone measures sustainable development.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: SDGs span poverty, health, education, environment and institutions; trade-offs and synergies matter.

Required reasoning. SDGs span poverty, health, education, environment and institutions; trade-offs and synergies matter.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes sdgs from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. SDGs span poverty, health, education, environment and institutions; trade-offs and synergies matter.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why sdgs may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 9

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: SDGs

(a) [10] Explain why progress toward one Sustainable Development Goal may affect another.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether energy access must conflict with climate action.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: SDGs span poverty, health, education, environment and institutions; trade-offs and synergies matter.

Required reasoning. More energy can support health and incomes; technology choice changes emissions.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes sdgs from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. More energy can support health and incomes; technology choice changes emissions.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why sdgs may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 10

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: SDGs

(a) [10] Explain why progress on poverty reduction can be undermined by environmental degradation.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether poverty policy should include environmental risks.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: SDGs span poverty, health, education, environment and institutions; trade-offs and synergies matter.

Required reasoning. Low-income households may depend on vulnerable land and resources; degraded ecosystems threaten livelihoods.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes sdgs from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Low-income households may depend on vulnerable land and resources; degraded ecosystems threaten livelihoods.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why sdgs may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 11

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: SDGs

(a) [10] Explain how education can contribute to both economic development and environmental sustainability.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether education alone can achieve the SDGs.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: SDGs span poverty, health, education, environment and institutions; trade-offs and synergies matter.

Required reasoning. Skills and awareness may improve livelihoods and resource choices, but finance and institutions remain essential.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes sdgs from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Skills and awareness may improve livelihoods and resource choices, but finance and institutions remain essential.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why sdgs may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 12

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: SDGs

(a) [10] Explain why measuring progress toward sustainable development requires more than GDP.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether composite indicators are sufficient for policy choices.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: SDGs span poverty, health, education, environment and institutions; trade-offs and synergies matter.

Required reasoning. Output omits distribution and ecological outcomes; indicator selection and data quality limit composites.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes sdgs from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Output omits distribution and ecological outcomes; indicator selection and data quality limit composites.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why sdgs may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 13

Hard | HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: HL poverty

(a) [10] Explain how poverty can encourage environmentally damaging resource use when households lack alternatives.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether reducing poverty always improves environmental quality.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: Immediate survival needs and limited technology can promote depletion, while higher consumption can also raise pressure.

Required reasoning. Immediate survival needs and limited technology can promote depletion, while higher consumption can also raise pressure.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes hl poverty from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Immediate survival needs and limited technology can promote depletion, while higher consumption can also raise pressure.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why hl poverty may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 14

Medium | HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: HL poverty

(a) [10] Explain how environmental degradation can reinforce poverty.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether a poverty-environment cycle can be broken without investment.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: Immediate survival needs and limited technology can promote depletion, while higher consumption can also raise pressure.

Required reasoning. Lost soil, fisheries or health reduces income and capacity to adopt cleaner practices.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes hl poverty from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Lost soil, fisheries or health reduces income and capacity to adopt cleaner practices.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why hl poverty may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 15

Medium | HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.7: HL poverty

(a) [10] Explain why access to cleaner technology can affect the relationship between poverty and sustainability.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether technology transfer alone can make development sustainable.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Sustainable development joins present well-being to the future ability to meet needs, with economic, social and environmental dimensions. Specifically: Immediate survival needs and limited technology can promote depletion, while higher consumption can also raise pressure.

Required reasoning. Affordable clean alternatives can reduce destructive use, but finance, skills and institutions matter.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes hl poverty from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Affordable clean alternatives can reduce destructive use, but finance, skills and institutions matter.

Counterargument and conditions. Income gains may expand resource use; cleaner technology and institutions can change the trade-off. For this focus, consider why hl poverty may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use named countries and particular UN SDG goals to compare economic, social and environmental outcomes. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Sources and scope

The current IB Economics guide controls syllabus boundaries. The uploaded Economics for the IB Diploma, second edition (2012), is a supplementary conceptual check; its older chapter sequence and content cannot expand the current specification. Real-world examples are optional and should be checked against their cited sources.

IB guide. Current Economics guide, Unit 4 Topic 4.7; syllabus scope, diagrams, calculations and SL/HL boundaries.

Open source

UN. Official SDG goals and targets.

Open source

Final checks

15 paired questions; 3 Easy, 8 Medium, 4 Hard; 12 questions assess SL/HL content; 3 questions are explicitly labelled HL. The student paper contains no answers or difficulty labels.